can be about 100 square Km. Mammals have specialized dietary needs such as carnivores, frugivores and the need to forage over much larger areas than general dietary herbivores and omnivores. Mammals also have low reproductive output other than small rodents.



The interrelationship and interdependence of all living components in a system can be seen from the example of the fruit bats of Guam (South East Asia). The fruit bats are a delicacy here, and hence their population has dwindled which is not surprising. What is surprising is that local fruit production has got affected as it was identified that the bats served as pollinators. Hence there is a need for conservation of diversity as that could avert such situations.

12.5 Causes of biodiversity loss

The major causes for biodiversity decline are:

- Habitat loss, fragmentation and destruction (affects about 73% of all species)
- Pollution and pollutants (smog, pesticides, herbicides, oil slicks, GHGs)
- Climate change
- Introduction of alien/exotic species
- Over exploitation of resources (poaching, indiscriminate cutting of trees, over fishing, hunting, mining)
- Intensive agriculture and aquacultural practices
- Hybridization between native and non-native species and loss of native species
- Natural disasters (Tsunami, forest fire, earth quake, volcanoes)
- Industrialization, Urbanization, infrastructure development, Transport – Road and Shipping activity, communication towers, dam construction, unregulated tourism and monoculture are common area of specific threats
- Co-extinction

Habitat Loss

Development of human society is inevitable. Natural habitats are destroyed for the purpose of settlement, agriculture, mining, industries and construction of highways. As a result species are forced to adapt to the changes in the environment or move to other places. If not, they become victim to predation, starvation, disease and eventually die or results in human animal conflict.

Over population, urbanization, industrialization and agricultural advancements require additional land, water and raw materials every year. This is made possible only through fragmentation or destruction of natural habitats by filling wetlands, ploughing grasslands, cutting down trees, forest, desilting rivers, constructing transport ways, caving mountains, extracting, ores, changing the course of rivers and filling of seashore.

The most dramatic example of habitat loss comes from the tropical rainforests 14% of the earth's land surface once covered by these tropical forests, is not more than 6% now. The Amazon rainforest, a vast area, harbouring millions of species, also called "Lungs of the planet"is destroyed and being replaced for agriculture and human settlements. 90% of New Zealand's wetlands have been destroyed and cleared for cultivating soya beans and raising grass for beef cattle. Kodaikanal and Nilgiri hills of Tamil Nadu have been

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